Kasi Yedumati · Full Stack Training

Lesson 1 — Introduction to FastAPI

Course: FastAPI for Full Stack · **Session 1 of 10** · Learning path

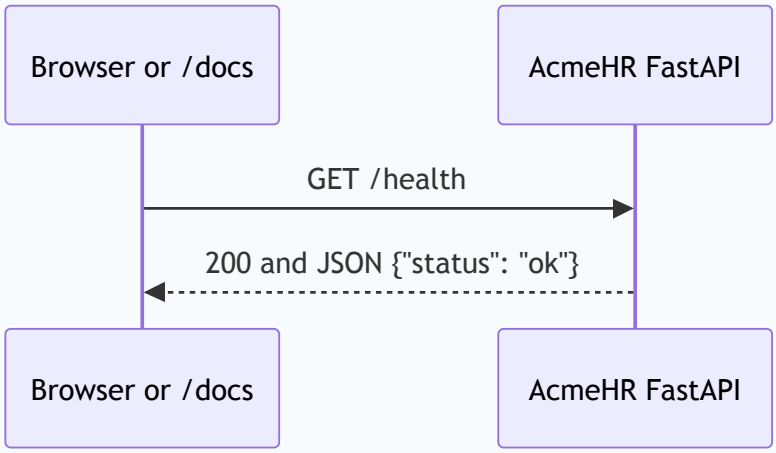
> **Module Outcome:** You can explain a request and a JSON response, run an AcmeHR API on your computer, and try it from the `/docs` page.

You will build	An AcmeHR API with `GET /` and `GET /health`
New words	API, request, response, JSON, status code, FastAPI, Uvicorn, route
You need	Python 3, VS Code, a terminal. A function and `python3 -m venv` are enough

Our project. All 10 lessons build **AcmeHR**, Acme's employee API. Today the API only says hello and reports that it is running. Later lessons add employees, MySQL, login, and the HTML page that calls it.

From the requirements. The AcmeHR screens (directory, profile, leave, attendance) will ask this API for data. Before any of that data exists, the team needs proof the API is up: open a URL, get an answer.

1. One request



- You are the **client**. The browser asks.
- FastAPI is the **server**. It answers.
- `GET /health` is the **request**. GET means "read". `/health` is the address.
- `{"status": "ok"}` is the **response** body. That text shape is **JSON**. It looks like a Python dictionary.
- **200** means the answer is fine. You will see **404** when the address is wrong.

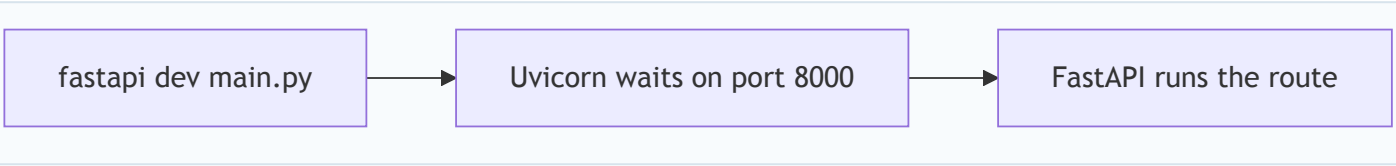
That picture is the idea. The rest of the page builds the right-hand side.

Word	In this API
API	A set of addresses the portal can call

Word	In this API
REST	Addresses plus a method. Today the method is GET and the address is `/health`
Route	The link between an address and a Python function

FastAPI is the library in your file. It turns a returned dictionary into JSON, and it builds the `/docs` page from your functions.

Start it with `fastapi dev main.py`. That command starts **Uvicorn**. Uvicorn waits on port 8000 and hands each request to FastAPI. The terminal line `Uvicorn running on http://127.0.0.1:8000` means Uvicorn is listening.



Some project READMEs show `uvicorn main:app --reload`. `main` is the file, `app` is the variable inside it. That starts the same server. The command to type here is `fastapi dev`.

	FastAPI	Django
What you get	Routes, JSON, and `/docs`	A full site: pages, admin, database, login
A good fit	The AcmeHR API	The AcmeHR website

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2. Project folder

Create this on your computer. It is the `acmehr-api` repository for the whole API.

```
acmehr-api/
├── venv/            ← created by the command below; do not commit it
└── main.py          ← the first file
```

```
mkdir acmehr-api
cd acmehr-api
python3 -m venv venv
source venv/bin/activate          # Windows: venv\Scripts\activate
pip install "fastapi[standard]"
```

`fastapi[standard]` installs FastAPI, the `fastapi` command, and Uvicorn. One install. The line above your prompt changes to `(venv)` after `activate`. Install packages only with that prefix showing.

Common error: `fastapi: command not found`, or `No module named fastapi`. The venv is not active, or `pip install` ran in a different terminal. Activate, install again, then start the server.

Common error: On Windows, `python3` may be `python`. Use the one that prints 3.11 or 3.12 for `python --version`.

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3. Hello, AcmeHR

Create `main.py`:

```
from fastapi import FastAPI

app = FastAPI(title="AcmeHR")

@app.get("/")
def home():
    return {"message": "Welcome to AcmeHR"}
```

File: `examples/lesson01/01_hello.py`

Line	Job
`from fastapi import FastAPI`	Brings in the class that holds your routes
`app = FastAPI(title="AcmeHR")`	Creates the API. The title shows on the `/docs` page
`@app.get("/")`	When someone reads `/`, call the next function
`def home():`	A normal Python function
`return {"message": ...}`	FastAPI turns this dictionary into JSON

Start it from the `acmehr-api` folder, with the venv active:

```
fastapi dev main.py
```

`main.py` is the file. Saving it restarts the server. The `app = FastAPI()` line is what `fastapi dev` finds and runs.

Output in the terminal:

```
INFO:     Uvicorn running on http://127.0.0.1:8000 (Press CTRL+C to quit)
INFO:     Started reloader process
INFO:     Application startup complete.
```

Open http://127.0.0.1:8000.

Output in the browser:

```
{"message":"Welcome to AcmeHR"}
```

Leave this terminal running. Use a second terminal for other commands.

Common error: `Address already in use`. A server is already bound to port 8000. Click that terminal and press `Ctrl + C`, then run `fastapi dev main.py` again.

Common error: The browser shows `{"detail":"Not Found"}`. The path in the address bar does not match a route. `/` and `/hello` are different addresses.

4. The health check

Add a second route to the same file and save. `fastapi dev` restarts. You should see `Application startup complete.` again.

```
from fastapi import FastAPI

app = FastAPI(title="AcmeHR")

@app.get("/")
def home():
    return {"message": "Welcome to AcmeHR"}

@app.get("/health")
def health():
    return {"status": "ok"}
```

File: `examples/lesson01/02_health.py`

Open http://127.0.0.1:8000/health.

Output:

```
{"status":"ok"}
```

The terminal logs the request:

```
INFO:     127.0.0.1:51234 - "GET /health HTTP/1.1" 200 OK
```

Open http://127.0.0.1:8000/docs. The page title is **AcmeHR**. Open **GET /health**, choose **Try it out**, then **Execute**. The response body is the same JSON, and the server response code is **200**.

That page is written from the two functions. You did not design it.

Common error: `GET /Health` returns 404. Paths are case-sensitive. The route is `/health`.

Common error: Opening `main.py` from the file explorer shows Python source, or nothing useful. The API is served at `http://127.0.0.1:8000`, not as a file.

Try these

1. **(Easy)** Change the welcome message to `AcmeHR API is running`. Save, refresh `/`, and confirm the new text. Reload is doing that work.
2. **(Easy)** Open `/docs` and execute `GET /`. Find the **200** in the result.
3. **(Medium)** Open `http://127.0.0.1:8000/employees`. Read the JSON. Find the matching **404** line in the terminal.
4. **(Medium)** Press `Ctrl + C` in the server terminal. Refresh `/health`. Start the server again with the venv active.
5. **(Stretch)** Add `GET /version` that returns `{"version": "1"}`. Execute it from `/docs`.

Interview: *What happens when a page calls an API?* — The client sends a request: a method and a path. The server runs the matching function and returns a status code and a body. Today that body is JSON, and 200 means it worked.

Interview: *What is* `/docs`*?* — A page FastAPI builds from your routes. You can call the API from that page before any frontend exists.

Interview: *Why does the terminal say Uvicorn when I typed* `fastapi dev`*?* — `fastapi dev` starts Uvicorn. FastAPI is your routes. Uvicorn is the program that waits on port 8000 and calls those routes.

Key takeaways

- The browser asks. FastAPI answers with a status code and JSON.
- `@app.get("/health")` connects that path to a function.
- A returned dictionary becomes JSON.
- `fastapi dev main.py` starts Uvicorn, which serves the API at `http://127.0.0.1:8000`.
- `/docs` lists the routes and can call them.

Lab — Ticket ACME-201

Homework

Next: Routing and HTTP methods. GET, POST, PUT, PATCH, and DELETE for an AcmeHR employee.